

EAGLE

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1B

The bird was in the same place, trying to fly overhead, Simmons said.

Then it crashed into the water and started to drown.

McDougald decided to go in. He waded in up to his chest with his clothes, shoes and socks still on.

"I decided that if [the water] went over my head I would give up," McDougald said.

Once he was close enough, McDougald cast the blanket out like a fishing net and scooped up the bird. He dragged it back to shore and put the blanket-covered bird in the cardboard box.

"With a wet blanket, a wet box and a wet bird, it weighed quite a bit," McDougald said. "But we carried it out."

They drove fast to Durham.

At the wildlife center, veterinarian Cheryl Hoggard was waiting for what she thought

JORDAN EAGLES

According to the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte:

■ As many as 30 to 40 eagles have been spotted at Jordan Lake. Several active nests are reported every year.

■ The N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission maintains a bald eagle observation platform for the public at the north end of the lake, just off N.C. 751.

■ While the bald eagle was once considered endangered, populations have recovered, and this species may soon be removed from the Endangered Species Act, which protects the bird and its habitat.

was an osprey.

But with the bird on the examining room table, "I'm looking down and seeing his feet," Hoggard said.

And those feet did not belong to an osprey.

There was no time to think about it.

She removed the hooks from the bird's foot and beak. In addition to its wounds, the bird was dehydrated after struggling for so long. She also heard gurgling in its upper-respiratory system, which meant it had breathed in water during the near drowning.

She gave the bird pain medication, antibiotics, and anti-inflammatory drugs.

Within 20 minutes, the bird was stabilized and put in a cage.

"He just hung his head and spread his wings because he was so exhausted," Hoggard said.

The next day, the bird was taken to the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte, which determined it was a 6-month-old male bald eagle. Young eagles don't have white-feathered heads like the birds on U.S. Postal Service trucks.

After letting the eagle rest for a few weeks, the raptor center placed him in a 100-foot-long fly cage for a month to get him back in shape.

Finally, on Thursday, he was well enough to return to the wild.

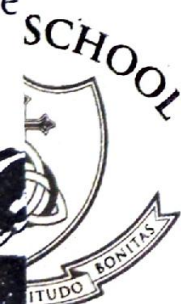
Mathias Engelmann, director of rehabilitation at the raptor center, drove the bird from Charlotte to Jordan Lake in a minivan.

Before letting him go, Engelmann donned arm-length gloves and cradled the bird before about 30 people, including Simmons and McDougald.

Then, on the count of three, Engelmann gave the bird a slight shove, and the eagle took off.

The bird circled the crowd a few times and disappeared over the lake.

Staff writer Leah Friedman can be reached at 932-2002 or leah.friedman@newsobserver.com.



Grounded Eagles To Be Bred

The Carolina Raptor Center will try to mate two injured golden eagles, with hopes of releasing the offspring to the wild.

The center in northern Mecklenburg County received a 2-year-old male bird Friday from a rehabilitation center in Utah and expects to receive a female bird Monday from Colorado.

The male, named Sweet Sue, was shot in one wing and is unable to fly, center Executive Director Pat Marcum said Saturday. The two birds will bring the center's golden eagle collection to five.

One eagle is used for educational classes, and the other two pairs, both flightless, are for breeding.